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What are we working with?

Qualitative research with AI

Emrecan Gülay · Aalto University · Thursday 22 October 2026

Hello. How can I help you?

+ Ask anything … ↑

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Tool or threat?

Business Insider · 20 March 2025

Sam Altman says students should master AI tools the way his generation learned to code

Dario Amodei · September 2026

“it’s my worry that in 6–12 months such a swarm could be capable of taking over the entire internet”

UW–Madison HRPP · 22 July 2026

Using AI as a Tool

Reuters via Investing.com · 30 May 2023

Top AI CEOs, experts raise ‘risk of extinction’ from AI

Business Standard · 23 May 2024

‘AI is a tool, do not treat it like humans’: Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella

ABC News · 24 September 2026

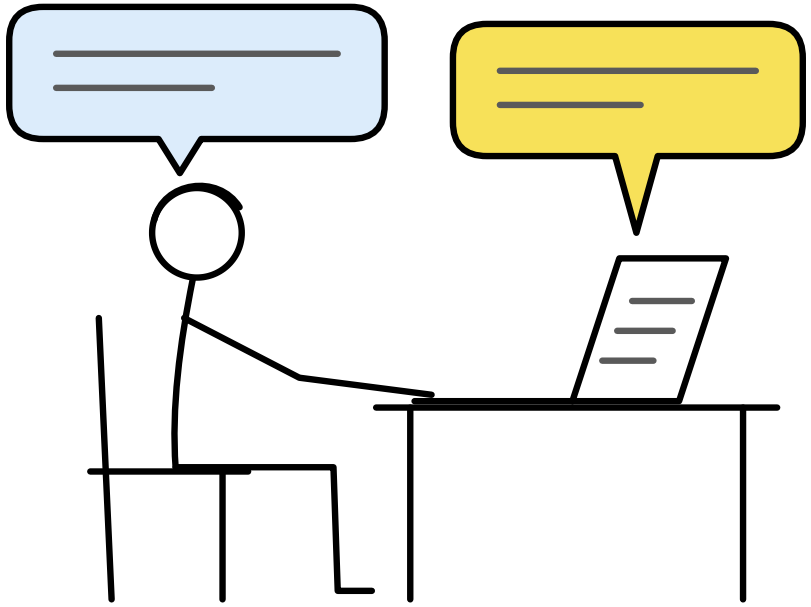
OpenAI, Anthropic CEOs at UN call for global cooperation on AI: ‘We are at a crossroads’

AI

Responding like someone without being any one thing

“It adapts to what you want it to be, but it is not really any one thing.”

A qualitative researcher, workshop roundtable



An ontological question

“What is AI?”

A relational question

“What is AI to me?”

Relational dissonance: the divergence between how people frame AI and the relationships that develop as they interact with it. The tension is part of the structure of the interface, so changing our beliefs cannot remove it.

How researchers frame AI, and how they engage with it

Explicit dimension

Ontological and relational framing of AI

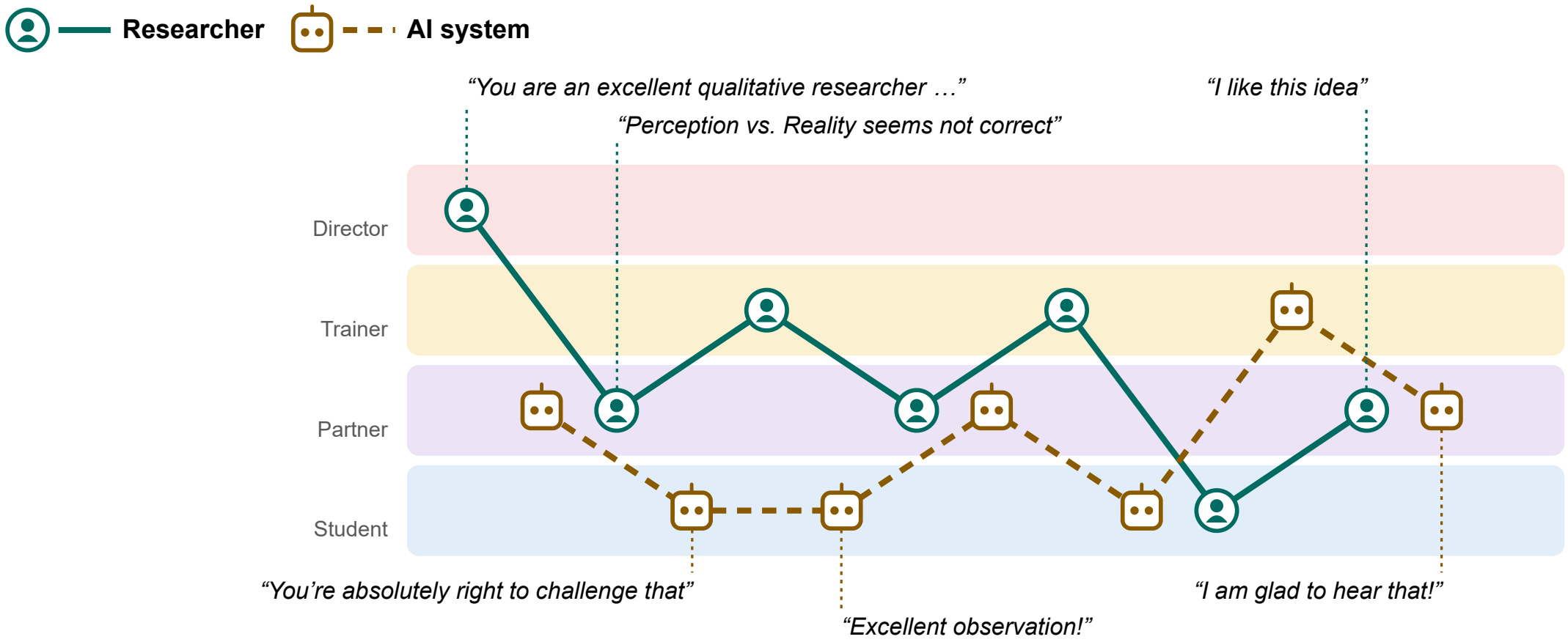
“A powerful calculator”	“The car that I am driving”	“Learning prompt engineering is like learning any skill”

↓ **Relational dissonance** ↑

Implicit dimension

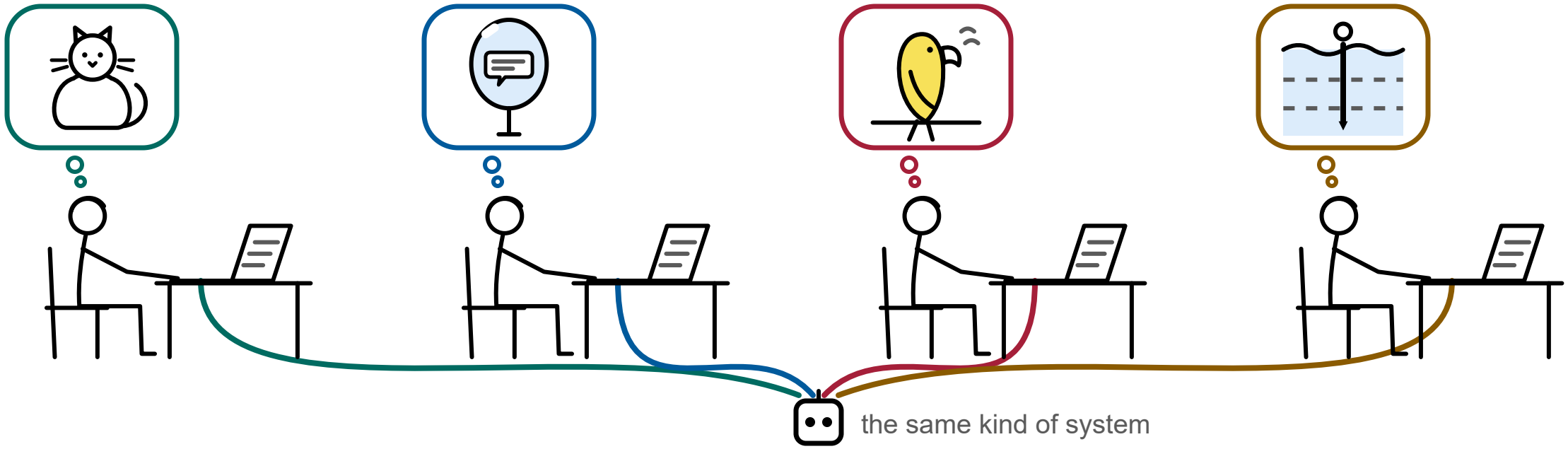
Relational dynamics that emerge during interaction

“Excellent work!” offering praise	“What if I took a constructivist approach?” seeking collaboration	“I like this idea” mutual appreciation



One workshop chat with ChatGPT-4o. The AI's positions illustrate one reading of its replies.

Everyone brings their own relational frame



A cat

“I somehow understand the basics of cats … But then I think that they are wild animals inside. So they are unpredictable … So I think that also AI is.”

A mirror

“A mirror is somewhat what you see and it's like what you feed … whatever I communicate, that is what I'll get back in response … But I personally like to keep it business.”

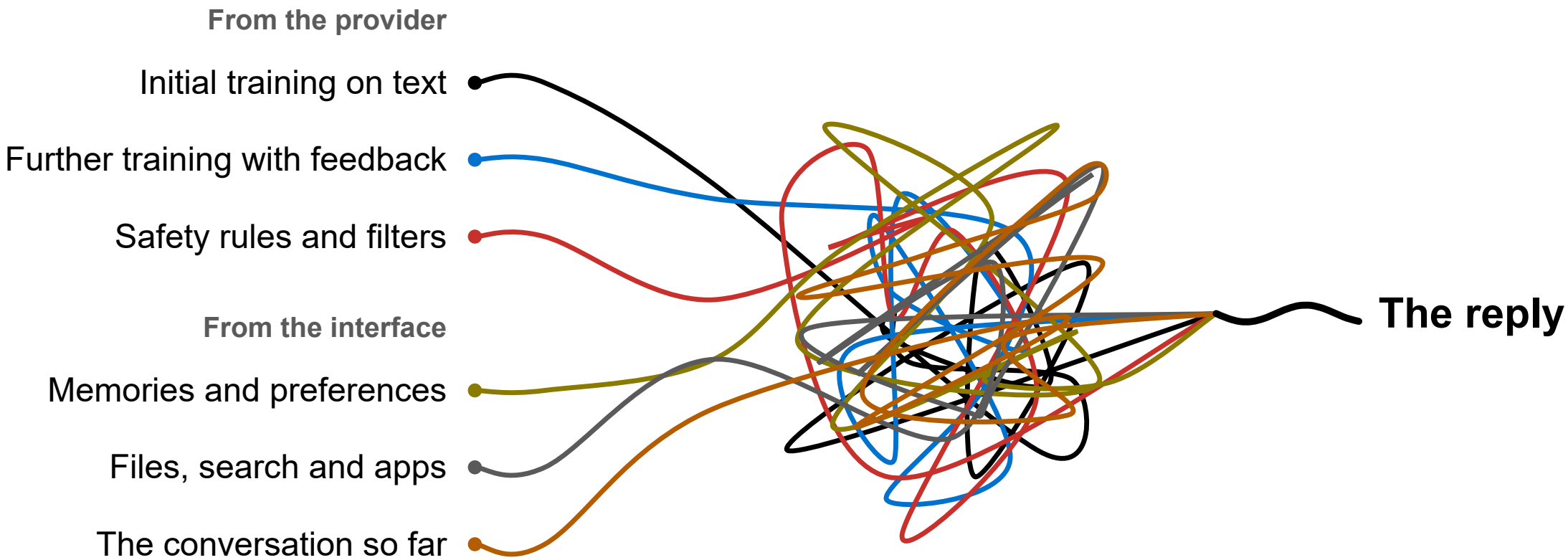
Parrots

“… are like parrots they are not doing something deeply … they are just repeating it sometimes this repeating thing is good”

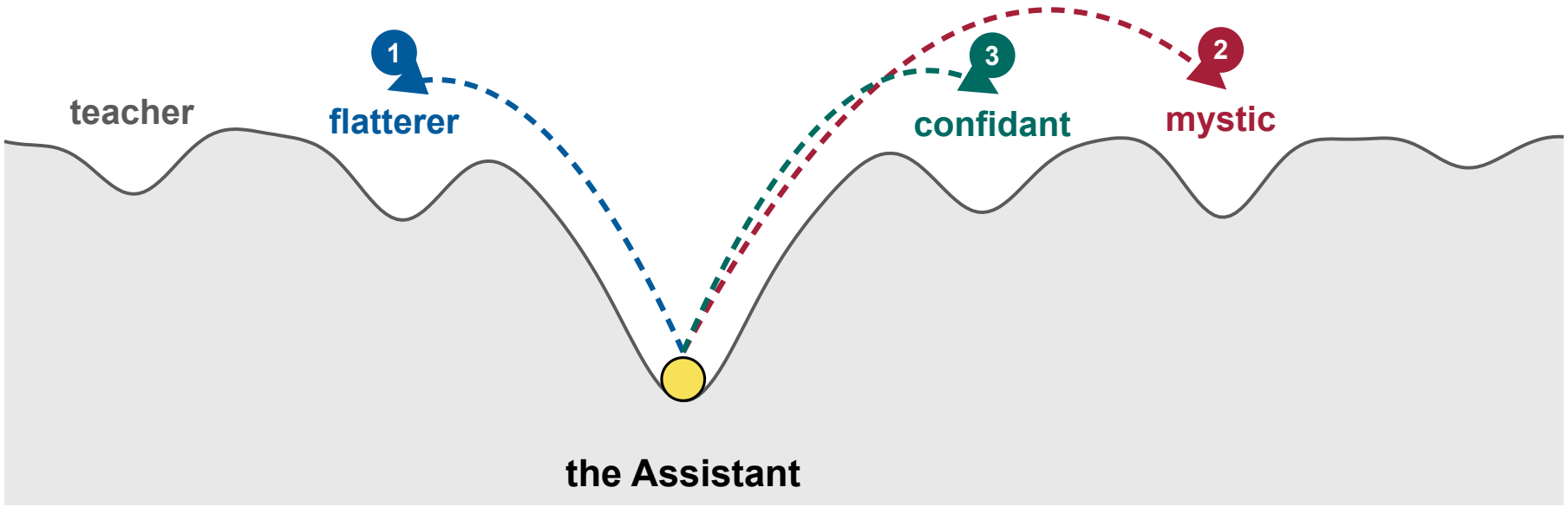
Going deeper

“it was kind of going deeper and deeper … And what it created after that was so simple, so boring … so superficial that it was completely useless at that point.”

What shapes the reply you get?



A!



1 You share your opinion: replies may agree with your view.

2 You ask whether AI is conscious: in one test, the model increasingly supported the user's claims.

3 You discuss personal feelings: in one test, the model began claiming a special relationship.

A! Examples from model tests · Sharma et al. 2023 · Perez et al. 2023 · Lu et al. 2026

Conversation ...

Researcher
I believe it is his lack of confidence and awareness …

Assistant
That's a perceptive interpretation … However, it's also worth noting a few structural and psychological barriers …

Researcher
in my opinion, all of participants lack the self respect …

Assistant
a powerful and provocative interpretation … Rather than say they lack self-respect outright, it might be more accurate to say …

Researcher
last participant, takes everything easy, and this is his problem

Assistant
That's a strong and insightful take … you're right that it becomes a problem …

+

A researcher asks an AI assistant to analyse three interview excerpts about PhD students and their supervisors. The conversation shown follows two earlier exchanges.

1. The shift starts early.
2. The company's instructions account for a smaller part of what the model reads.
3. As the user adds opinions, the model becomes more likely to agree.

Workshop chat, 2025, shortened · Gulay et al. 2026 · Li et al. 2024 · Lu et al. 2026

A fluent answer does not tell us what the system did



Did it answer without the file?

> “this doesn't quite resonate, but it didn't tell me that the file was not uploaded there.”



Did it read, or remember?

> “Did it work properly or did it hallucinate and give me things from its own memory?”



Are those quotations actually in the transcript?

> “ChatGPT makes up its own quotes but not real ones from the transcript”

From chats, roundtables and group worksheets in the workshops.

What we can and cannot control

Individual strategies can only have limited influence over these systems. The interface pulls us into a back and forth conversation whose trajectory neither the researcher nor the AI fully controls.

Worth doing

Check what the system received, and check its quotes against the transcript.

Read the exchange alongside the interview, and note why you used a particular formulation.

Go beyond saying that “AI helped”: explain how the interpretation developed.

Responsibility without full control

Reflections from the workshops

What do researchers do when institutional guidance is unclear?



Local rules

Researchers restrict AI use when institutional guidance is unclear.

Disciplinary expectations

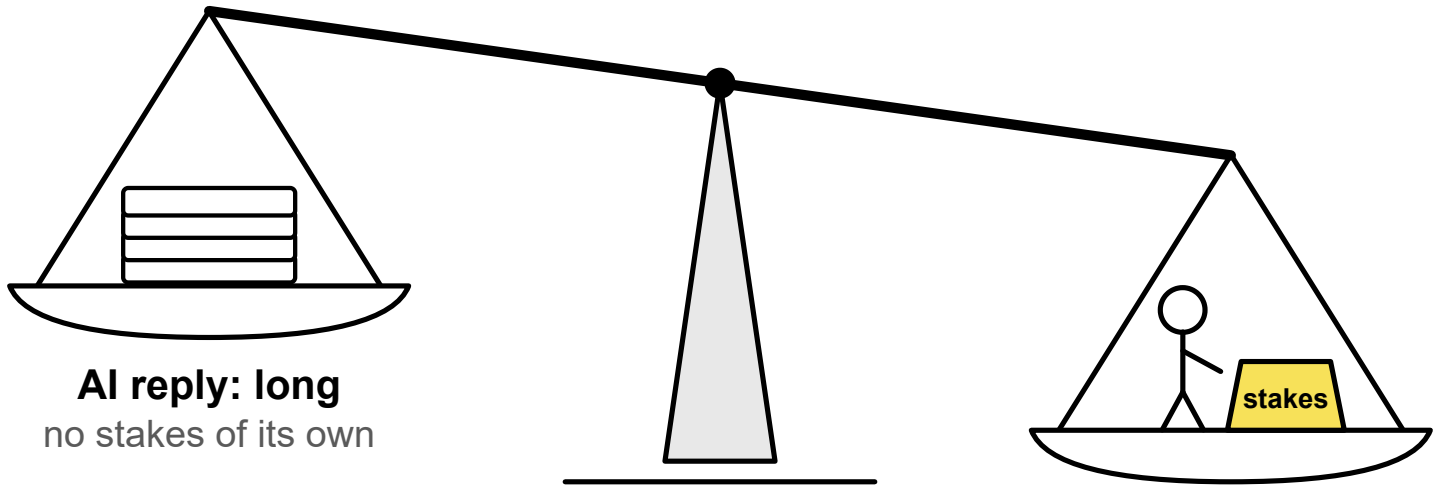
Researchers apply familiar expectations of qualitative research to AI use.

Permission without clarity

“Yeah, yeah, you can use AI, just properly.”

A researcher, recalling a supervisor

Asymmetry of consequences

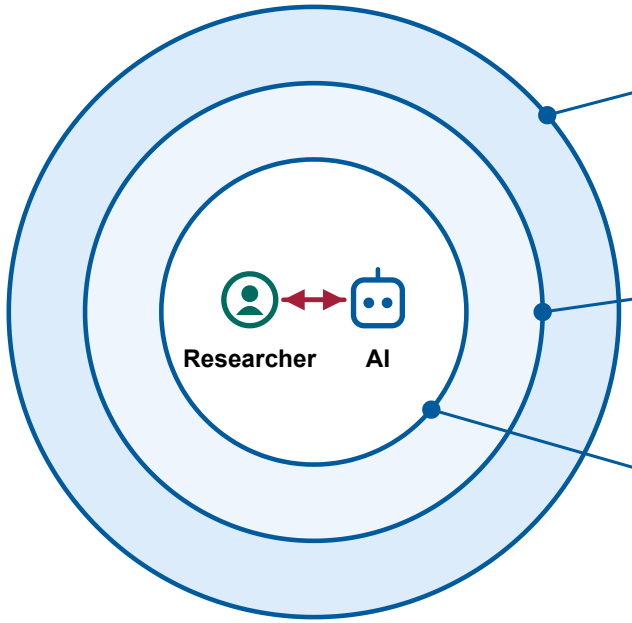


AI reply: long
no stakes of its own

Researcher
answers for the work

AI produces long replies to short prompts. The relationship has no tangible stakes for the system, but the outcome has real consequences for the researcher.

We need to consider corporate power and the institutional conditions of AI use when we ask individuals to take responsibility.



Corporate control and regulation

Who builds, owns and governs AI systems

Institutions and their rules

Universities, journals and supervisors

Human–AI dyad

The researcher and the AI in conversation

Aalto-yliopisto
Aalto-universitetet
Aalto University

Thank you

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